

The chase ended in a blur of dust and grit, Dwight thrashing weakly across his shoulder. Caleb strode for the gallows, ignoring the boy's fists drumming against his back. The Entity wanted her quota filled, but she'd let him play so long as he delivered eventually. And this time? He had something better in mind.

Dwight tensed as they reached the hook, braced for the spike through his shoulder. He pressed against Caleb's coat, instinct primed for pain. But instead of the punch of steel, he found himself dumped unceremoniously onto the planks. For a beat, he just lay there, disoriented—blinking grit out of his eyes, heart pounding in his throat. What the hell was he doing? Caleb never missed a hook.

The clatter of metal snapped him out of it. The harpoon clicked free of its lock, chain hissing as it unspooled. Dwight scrambled, trying to find his feet, but the uneven boards shifted under him, his limbs misfiring with panic. Caleb was already moving. With a flick of his wrist, he tossed the gun up over the gallows bar. Metal rang against iron as it looped and came down. Before Dwight could bolt, the line cinched tight around his throat and yanked him upright in a choking lurch.

"Up. Stand tall," Caleb drawled, hauling back on the harpoon end of the chain until Dwight's heels barely scraped the wood. "She don't mind how I hang you, long as you hang."

Dwight staggered, legs scrambling for balance. Caleb gave another jerk and wrenched him onto his toes. His hands flew to the chain overhead, slick with sweat already, as his throat spasmed around the pressure.

"On your toes, boy. Don't slack now."

The chain lowered link by link until Dwight found wooden planks under his feet again, just barely. He pulled himself up as high as he could, gasping—catching a half-breath before it was stolen again. The chain rattled cruelly as Caleb toyed with the slack, jerking him higher onto his toes before letting him sag down again. Then up. Then down. Each adjustment stole more strength than he could afford, dragging out his panic with surgical precision.

Caleb's grin twitched under his mustache. "Funny how quick a man'll fight for inches once the ground's gone."

Finally seeming pleased with the length, Caleb wedged the harpoon head deep into the gears of the hook, locking it in place. His new decoration dangled there, arms stretched, legs trembling, every breath ragged. Caleb retreated to the rail, content to watch the strained wobble, Dwight

barely able to stay upright, chin straining above the choke. He leaned against the railing with quiet satisfaction.

“That’s a good stretch,” he muttered, low and amused. “Hell, I could watch you fight for hours. Pity I don’t have the time.”

With an almost lazy, casual cruelty, Caleb turned and aimed a kick at a nearby lever, knocking the trapdoor open.

The floor dropped.

Dwight didn’t. Not all the way. But he felt it—the jerk, the instant his toes lost even the illusion of purchase, the bite of the chain that dragged tighter across his throat.

His lungs hadn’t caught up, still primed for a hook through muscle. His brain screamed incoherent panic as his hands locked around the chain above, slippery with sweat, each link sliding like sand through his grip.

Don’t slip—don’t slip—don’t slip—

He clawed higher, shoulders already screaming. Caleb chuckled, tipping his hat.

“Don’t you be going nowhere, now.”

The chain rattled above as Caleb turned away without a backward glance, disappearing over the railing with a graceful vault and a low, satisfied hum, leaving his improvised ornament trembling in the air.

Chunk 2

Dwight’s body had no time to catch up. His lungs still thought they’d be screaming from steel in his shoulder, not strangled by his own weight. Panic lagged a heartbeat behind, then surged all at once as the line jolted tighter and stole the breath straight out of him.

He clawed overhead, fingers locking on links slick with sweat. They slid anyway. Each notch lost was a bite of air he couldn’t reclaim, each slip lowering his chin closer to the choke. His shoulders burned, tendons stretched to fire. His legs scrabbled against nothing, toes brushing only empty air.

Breathing came ragged, shallow. His own weight pressed him down, grinding him weaker by the second. Every gasp was effort spent just to keep his airway open, arms trembling, muscles faltering.

Somewhere below, wood creaked under new boots on the stairs. Dwight barely noticed. Every inch of him was focused on not letting go.

Another link slipped. His chin dipped. Burned air hissed in through clenched teeth. He couldn't tear his focus away from the links sliding through his grip. One slip too many and he'd be done.

Bill hit the gallows hard, boots pounding up the wooden steps, gravel voice ripping Dwight's name as he prepared to pull the boy down from the hook. He had to move fast. This was one of the worst hooks for being too open. Too easy to see from a distance. Cresting the top step, he froze. This wasn't the hook he had been expecting.

Dwight dangled over the previously unused trapdoor, chain taut across his throat, arms stretched overhead in a shaking lock. His legs kicked at empty air, finding no purchase. Not hooked. Not bleeding. Just hanging—alive and choking, and Bill had no damn blueprint for this.

Instinct shoved him forward anyway. He reached for Dwight's torso, trying to drag him in, only to feel the sickening tilt of balance as his boots slid toward the trapdoor. A lurch in his gut warned him plain: one inch more and he was gone, and instinct would make him clutch Dwight on the way down. Two hundred and fifty pounds snapping the kid's legs and neck in an instant.

He jerked back with a curse, staggering a few feet away. Pacing. Hands flexing. There had to be a way to get the kid down that wasn't going to make it worse. He turned towards the hook, swinging gently on its tower, and locked eyes on the harpoon wedged above.

Grasping at the handle, Bill pulled on the harpoon, trying to dislodge it. It stayed firm, as if part of the hook tower itself. He wasn't going to be able to shift it on his own. He would need an extra set of hands. Thankfully, he could make out a generator chugging away in the cacti down below.

"Jake!" Bill barked, slamming against the railing, voice cracking like gunfire. "Get your ass up here, now!"

The order was raw, desperate, but sharp enough to cut through the chaos. If Dwight was going to live, he'd need more than Bill's grip and curses. He needed teamwork—and fast.

Jake jerked up from his crouch near the cactus, heart pounding. He'd been waiting for Caleb and Dwight to pass so he could get working on this generator, but the raw desperation in Bill's voice left no room to hesitate. He sprinted for the gallows.

He hit the steps at speed, taking them two at a time. Bill was already braced at the hook, fists locked on the harpoon jammed into the gears. He heaved with a growl, metal groaning, Dwight stretched and straining on the chain. The older man spat a curse, smoke curling from the mangled stub of his cigarette.

Jake lunged for Dwight's arm, instinct overriding caution—but Bill's grip clamped his shoulder hard, dragging him back from the edge. "You'll take him down with you. Help me pull this out!"

Jake froze for half a second. The danger hit him like a blow—what he'd nearly done. His stomach twisted.

They turned to the harpoon together, hauling from both sides. It shrieked with the grind of metal on metal but didn't shift, wedged too deep. Caleb had driven it home with more than human strength. Jake's gut sank. Brute force wouldn't be enough.

His eyes tracked the chain again, up over the gallows beam, back to the head jammed into the gears. The angle was wrong from down here—there was no way to pry it free without leverage.

Jake spat grit from his teeth, made his decision. "I'm going up."

He gripped the hook tower, skittering up the frame like a man possessed. Splinters bit into his palms, wood groaned beneath his boots, but he climbed higher, legs braced wide against the frame. The whole thing shuddered.

At the top he wrapped both hands around the harpoon and wrenched while Bill continued pulling from below. Metal screamed, vibration rattling Dwight below like a pendulum, but it still didn't budge. He tried kicking at it, changing the angle or snapping the end off. No luck. Jake hissed, sweat stinging his eyes. All he'd done was jostle Dwight's already tentative grip, losing him a couple more chain links in the process.

Jake locked eyes with Bill for a moment, the rough outline of an idea sparking. If the harpoon wouldn't budge, he would just have to take the whole tower mechanism down. Sabotage. He knew these hooks—every gear, every catch. If he cracked the mechanism, the hook would fall free from the gears, and the harpoon would fall with it.

"Bill! Get under him!" Jake shouted, voice sharp. "I'm taking it down! When it gives, he's falling straight through. You've gotta catch him!"

Bill wasted no time, boots pounding down the steps as Jake dug his fingers into the machinery, searching the jagged edges for a weak point. The gears shuddered under his weight. He didn't have long. Dwight's grip was already bleeding out, one slip at a time.

Dwight's arms were gone. The tremors had grown into violent shakes, shoulders locked and screaming. His palms burned where the chain ground against them, each link sawing deeper as sweat slicked his grip. Every pull bought him less, every slip cost more.

There had never been much slack. Caleb had stretched him to the limit—on his toes before the floor dropped. Now, with nothing beneath, his hold wasn't lifting him anymore, only staving off the choke. The chain was taut across his throat, every ounce of his weight pressing down.

His breaths rasped in shallow jerks, throat raw. He tried to haul himself higher, but his fingers only locked stiff and slipped again, the metal rattling above his ears. His vision tunneled, black flecks dancing.

Somewhere close, voices clashed—Bill's bark, Jake's reply—but they reached him muffled, blurred by the rush of blood in his ears. The chain shrieked as hands fought at the harpoon above, each jolt swinging him like a pendulum. Every rattle jarred his shoulders, every sway robbed him of another gasp.

Another slip. His chin dipped lower. Fingers locked awkwardly, refusing to obey. He could feel the last of his strength bleeding out. His hands were seizing now. Cramping.

Too high—too tight—can't breathe—

The world narrowed to heat and steel and screaming shoulders.

The gears shrieked as Jake's sabotage finally bit. Metal screamed. The hook jolted loose. In a blink the chain snapped free. Jake yanked his arm back just in time to avoid the recoil as the harpoon shot back, dragged sharply away by the weight on the other side. Dwight dropped—limbs limp, panic strangled silent—as he tumbled through the trapdoor.

Bill lunged underneath, arms locking around Dwight's ribs as the two of them hit the dirt in a bruising heap. The impact knocked the air from his lungs and jabbed fire through his hip. His knees buckled, his spine lit up—but he held tight, shielding Dwight from the worst of it until the chain slackened loose.

Dwight wheezed, spots bursting across his vision, arms twitching weakly as Bill tore the metal links from around his throat. He sagged half-boneless atop the older man, chest dragging in ragged jerks, the angry grooves of chain livid against his skin.

For a long beat there was only breath—Bill's harsh and steady, Dwight's broken and stuttering. Jake clung white-knuckled to the edge of the trapdoor above, staring down through sweat-stung eyes, waiting to see if they'd actually done it in time.

Dwight coughed, deep and painful, spots flashing in his vision. He blinked slowly, voice shredded.

"...I think I hate that guy."

Bill snorted, half relief, half disbelief, trying not to wince at the bruise blooming under his spine. "Yeah, well... get in line."

Jake barked out a laugh then, sharp and a little wild, spilling loose from where he dangled over the edge. Relief, hysteria—it didn't matter. The sound broke the tension like a snapped rope, echoing across the gallows.

A whistle floated through the mist. Low. Casual.

Caleb was still out there.

The chain lay coiled in the dirt beside them, the mark of a moment survived—but not escaped.

